



SELECTING A DEFENSE COMMITTEE

MASTER'S: Your Defense Committee will require a minimum of 3 members including your Advisor and a Chairperson. Your advisor and the Chairperson must be UVM graduate faculty. The Chairperson must be from outside your department and program including primary and secondary appointments. All members must be present at the defense unless permission has been granted in advance by the Graduate College for participation via teleconference. If a member is attending via teleconference you will still need to obtain an original signature on the Acceptance Page of your thesis or dissertation paper. The Chairperson must always be present at the defense and your Defense Committee must be approved by the Graduate College prior to your defense. You must submit a Defense Committee Membership Form (attached)* at the beginning of the semester you plan on defending.

DOCTORATE: Your Defense Committee will consist of a minimum of 4 members of the University of Vermont Graduate Faculty including your Advisor and a Chairperson. At least two members must be from inside your department or program. The Chairperson must be both a member of the graduate faculty and from outside your department and program, including primary and secondary appointments. The definition of outside faculty means the faculty member has no appointment of any kind in the department or program. *When appropriate, a non-UVM faculty or non-graduate faculty member may serve as an additional member on the Defense Committee if approved by the Graduate Dean. A written request from the advisor and current curriculum vitae from the proposed additional committee member are required by the Graduate College.* All members must be present at the defense unless permission has been granted in advance by the Graduate College for participation via teleconferencing. If a member is attending via teleconference you will still need to obtain an original . The Chairperson must always be present at the defense and your Defense Committee must be approved by the Graduate College prior to your defense. You must submit a Defense Committee Membership Form (attached)* at the beginning of the semester you plan on defending.

YOUR THESIS/DISSERTATION ADVISOR: This advisor is typically your scholarly mentor - a faculty member in your program who works most closely with you as you proceed through all phases of your research. Your advisor usually has specific expertise in the field of your scholarship and offers guidance in the structure, content and methodology of the work. The advisor also assures that you are aware of current standards for the actual thesis or dissertation manuscript, its organization and format. The additional members of your thesis/dissertation defense committee are typically selected based upon specific types of expertise they hold as well. For example, you may identify a faculty member who has worked extensively with a certain type of experimental design that you are using, or perhaps the individual's scholarship has adopted a different but complementary theoretical perspective. In any case, the committee member might help you consider alternative or more in-depth ways of thinking about certain aspects of your scholarly project.

THE ROLE OF THE CHAIRPERSON: The Chair serves quite a different role. First and foremost, the Chair is responsible for assuring that the procedures and standards of UVM's Graduate College are met as you complete and defend your thesis/dissertation, to ensure that the UVM degree you earn reflects some common standard of accomplishment across the University. The Chair is the objective "outsider" (vis-a-vis your program) capable of ascertaining that the thesis and defense are meeting university-wide standards and guidelines and not merely those that are idiosyncratic to your department or program. At the same time, the Chair is there to assure that you, the student, are receiving full and fair attention from the committee--the sort of opportunity and treatment due to each and every student in UVM's Graduate College. So, the Chair is at once a student advocate and also ensures compliance with standards for the College as a whole.

Often a student tries to identify a Chair who also has scholarly expertise closely related to the thesis/dissertation. This can be quite helpful but it is not necessary. In fact, very interesting, and important contributions can be made by a Chair who has considerable distance from the field of inquiry. Approaching the issues from a different discipline, an individual can ask insightful questions and offer innovative perspectives that may be overlooked by those who have long been immersed in the traditions.

Our advice is to be thoughtful and creative as you work to assemble a thesis/dissertation committee. Consider your own background - its strengths and its gaps - as well as those of your advisor; ask yourself what sorts of support you would find helpful (scholarly, motivational, practical, psychological, etc.) and try to identify committee members who can contribute accordingly. Then relax and take advantage of the different skills and insights your committee members can bring to bear on your work. The system is designed to support the development of first-rate scholarship on your part.



DEFENSE COMMITTEE MEMBERSHIP FORM

As soon as you have selected your committee, please fill out this form and e-mail it as an attachment to the Graduate College at gradcoll@uvm.edu , or drop it off at 330 Waterman.

Candidate's Name _____ Phone _____ Date _____

Program _____ Degree _____ E-mail _____

Proposed graduation date of _____ (select one) _____ (year)

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	Name	Dept/School	Graduate Faculty? (Check if yes)
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Advisor	_____	_____	
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Committee member	_____	_____	
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Committee member	_____	_____	
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Committee member	_____	_____	
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Chairperson	_____	_____	
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Chairperson's campus address _____

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Graduate College Approval Signature _____ Date: _____